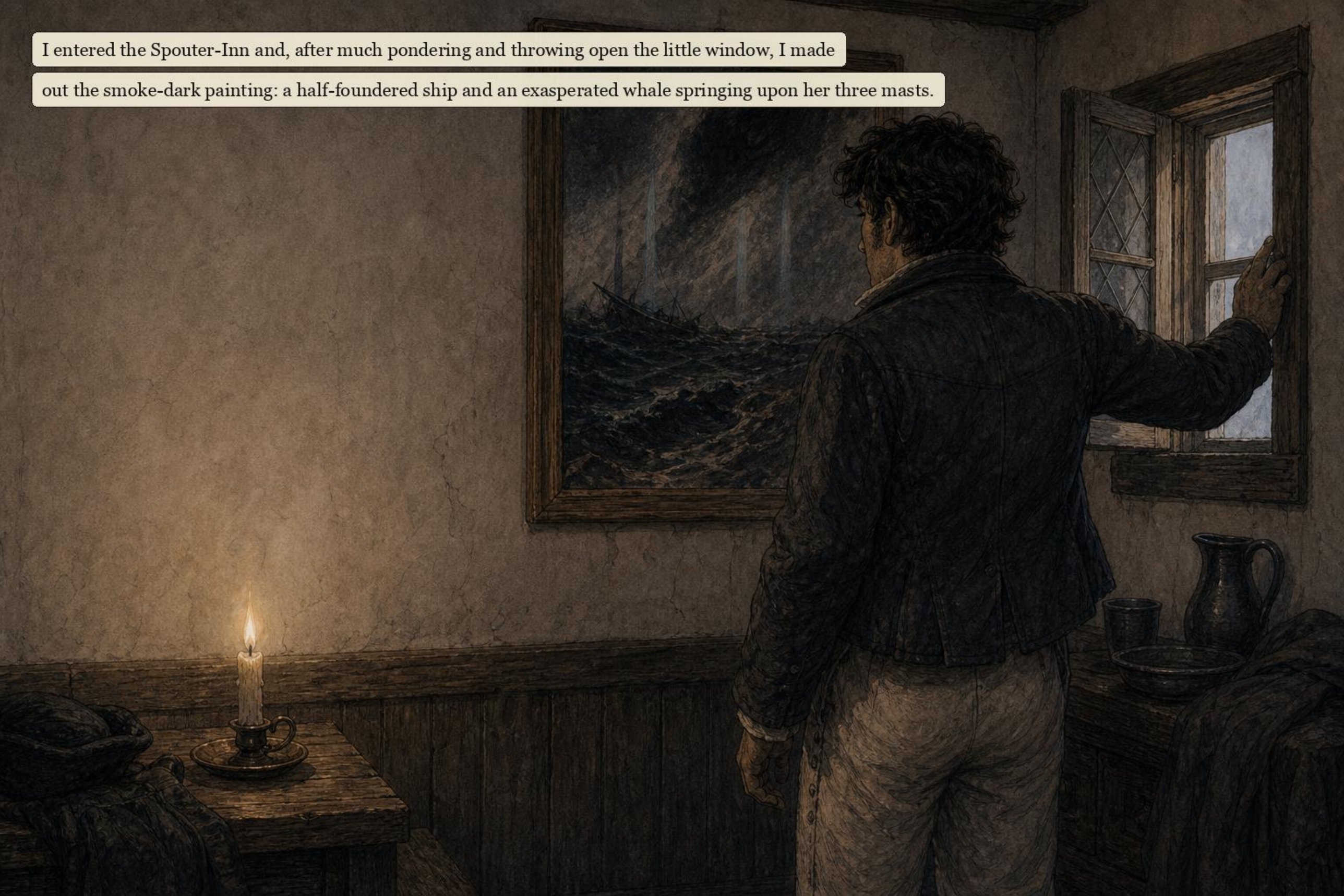
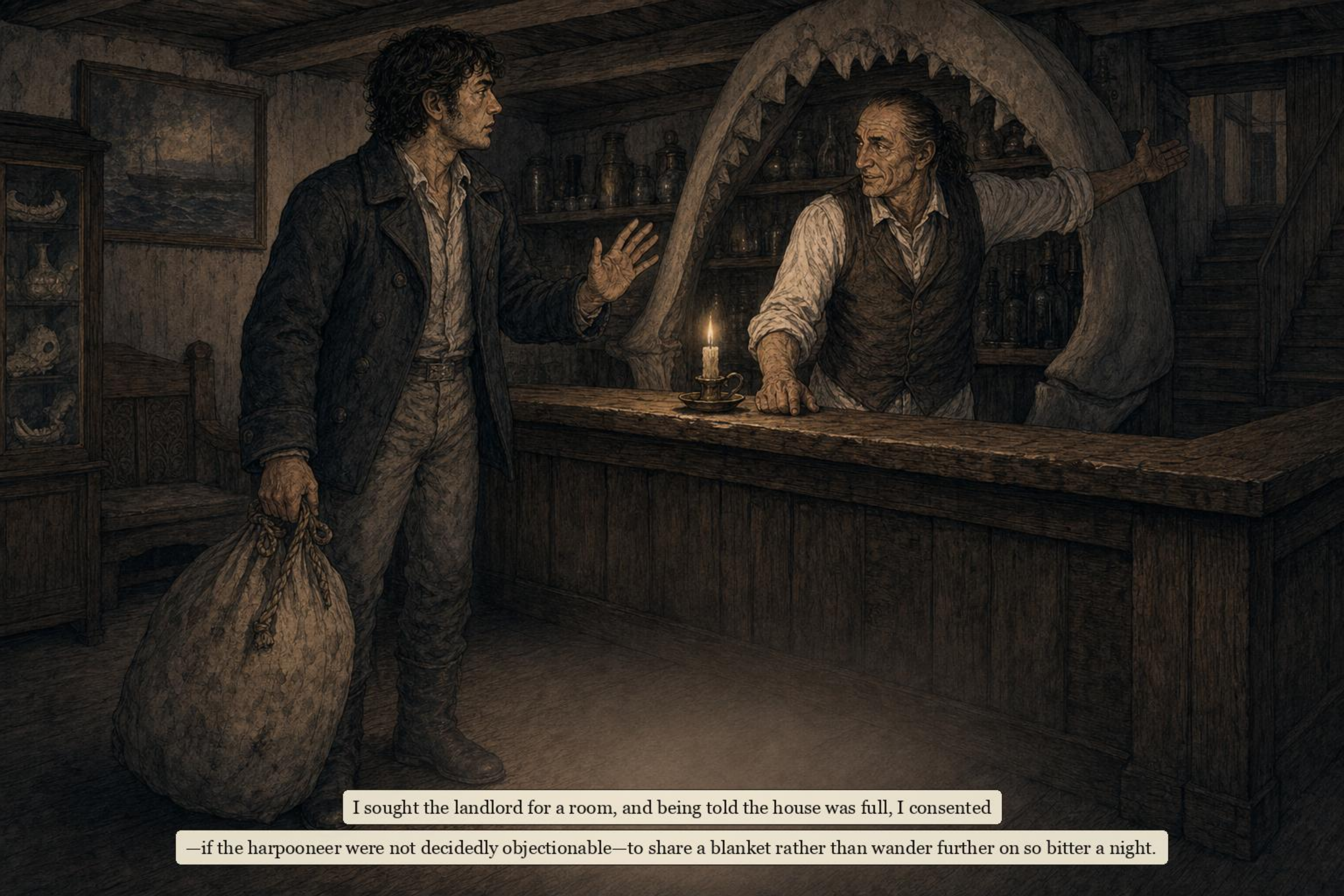
I entered the Spouter-Inn and, after much pondering and throwing open the little window, I made out the smoke-dark painting: a half-foundered ship and an exasperated whale springing upon her three masts.





I sought the landlord for a room, and being told the house was full, I consented

—if the harpooneer were not decidedly objectionable—to share a blanket rather than wander further on so bitter a night.

I changed my mind about that harpooneer, chose the bench, and soon learned that knots, a foot too short, and the meeting draughts would never do

—while the landlord kept chuckling that the fellow was out ‘selling his head.’

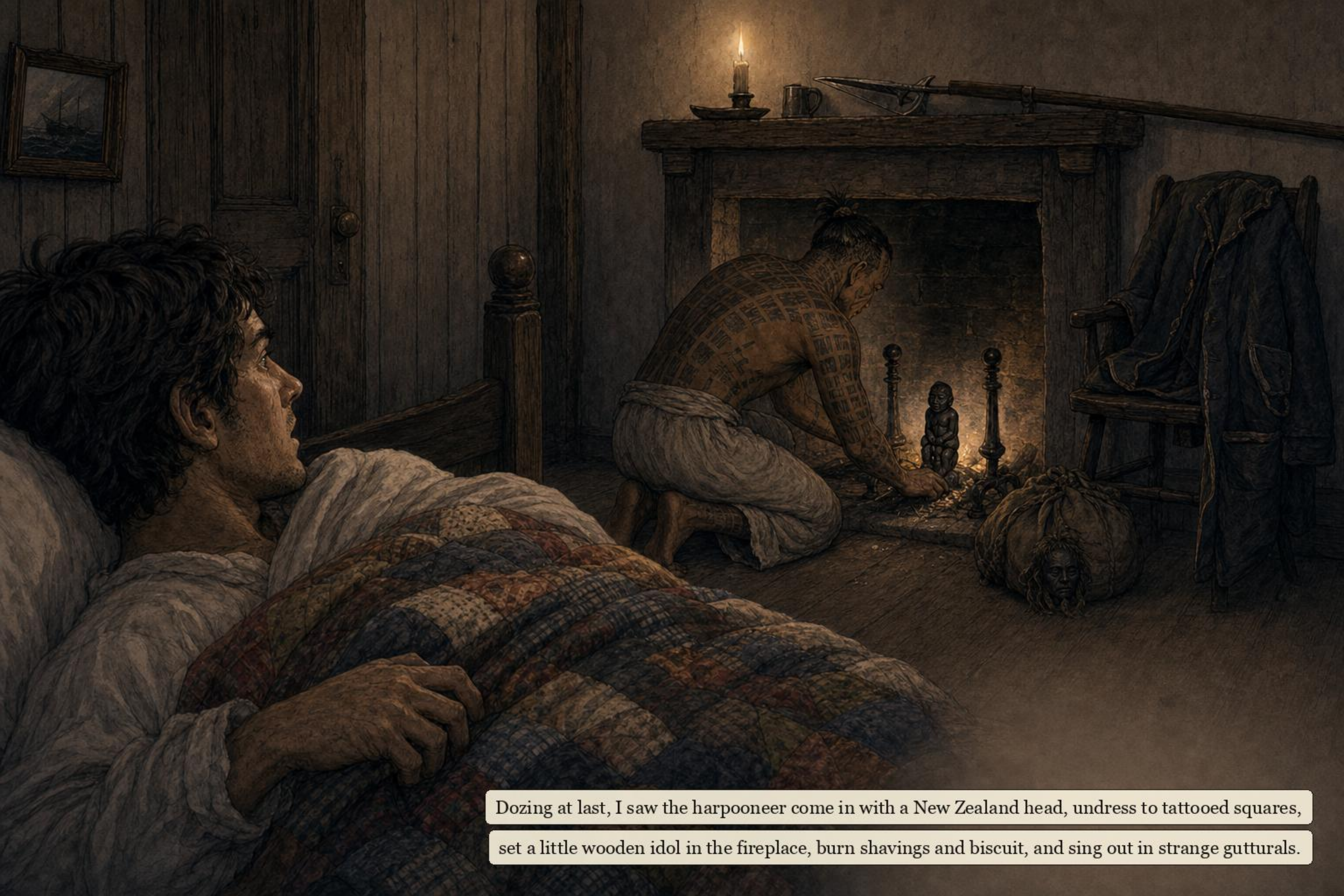




Provoked by his bamboozling yarn of selling his head, I demanded the truth, and heard it plain—embalmed New Zealand heads, peddled on a Saturday night.

Seeing it was Sunday and he'd come to anchor elsewhere, I let the landlord lead me to the prodigious bed; I eyed the room and the harpooneer's outlandish gear, then turned in.





Dozing at last, I saw the harpooneer come in with a New Zealand head, undress to tattooed squares,

set a little wooden idol in the fireplace, burn shavings and biscuit, and sing out in strange gutturals.

Then, tomahawk-pipe between his teeth, he sprang into bed with me; I sang out, and the landlord burst in with a light to swear the harpooneer, Queequeg, wouldn't harm a hair of my head.





Better sleep with a sober cannibal than a drunken Christian, thought I; he stashed the tomahawk-pipe, I turned in again, and never slept better in my life.